

The mighty Pacific Ocean covers almost half the planet.

WATER OF LIFE

Life depends on liquid water. This is because water can dissolve the chemicals needed to make the proteins and other complex substances that form living things. Seawater in particular contains most of these vital chemicals, and it is likely that life on Earth began in the oceans, more than 3.5 billion years ago. The oceans and seas are still ideal habitats for life of all kinds.



School of striped mackerel

GLITTERING VARIETY

The oceans of the world include a huge variety of habitats. They range from icy polar waters to warm coral seas, and from the glittering, sunlit surface to the inky darkness and numbing cold of the ocean depths. The nature of each habitat has shaped the animals that have evolved to live in it, creating an amazing diversity of life.



Pacific sea nettle

FRONTIER ZONE

For centuries, the oceans have been used as trade routes and as a rich source of food and minerals. But they are also incredibly dangerous, and this is one reason why the deep oceans are still largely unexplored. Amazingly, we know more about the surface of the Moon than we do about the deep ocean floor.

